



An illustration from Edward Fitzgerald's translation of the *Rubaiyat*; of the 600 verses, only around 120 are thought to have been written by Khayyam himself.

SOMETIME AROUND THE START OF THE 12TH CENTURY, OMAR KHAYYAM (1048–1131), an astronomer and mathematician in the service of the **Seljuk sultans**, composed a series of four-line poems, or “*roba’iyat*,” which became famous thanks to the translation made by **Edward Fitzgerald** in 1859. Khayyam's career reflected the Seljuk era. At **Samarkand**, in the early 1070s, he was able to pursue his **mathematical studies** thanks to patronage from a local jurist, and under the strong Seljuk sultan **Malik Shah** (r. 1072–92), Khayyam was invited to **Isfahan** in 1073 to **set up an observatory** and lead a team of top scholars. In this period he made many **mathematical and astronomical breakthroughs**, including an unprecedented accurate measurement of **the length of the year** to 12 decimal places. Although he is now most famous for the *Rubaiyat*, it is not certain that Khayyam wrote most or any of the verses involved, and he was little regarded as a poet in his own time. Much of the current reputation of the work derives from the very free translation by Edward Fitzgerald.

The success of the **First Crusade** (see 1091–1100) owed



much to the disarray of the Islamic regimes it had dispossessed. The **Fatimid Caliphate** in Cairo was rich but decadent; the **Abbasids** in Baghdad were little more than figureheads; the **Seljuk Turks** had failed to forge a unified empire, and instead warlords and tribal groups had set up a patchwork of competing states such as **Rum**, **Danishmend**, and **Damascus**. Throughout the early 12th century, the Crusaders battled

constantly against these foes. In 1101, **Raymond IV of Toulouse** (c. 1042–1105) led a new Crusader

Baldwin of Bourcq
This coin features Baldwin of Bourcq, cousin of Baldwin I, who he succeeded as count of Edessa, then as king of Jerusalem (see 1118).

army from **Constantinople** against the Sultanate of Rum, taking **Ankara** in June, only to be destroyed by Danishmend Turks in August. **Baldwin I of Jerusalem** (c. 1058–1118) steadily improved his access to the Mediterranean by taking a series of coastal cities from the **Fatimids**, defeating them at **Jaffa** in 1102, **Acre** in 1104, and **Ramleh** in 1105, although Raymond died in an attempt to take **Tripoli** in 1105.



Monumental ruins in the city of Great Zimbabwe, capital of the Mwene Mutapa Empire. After it seized control of the gold trade, the empire grew rich.

NOTED FOR ITS FINE ARTS AND CRAFTS and construction of **monumental temple mounds**, the post-Moche culture, known as the **Sicán** or **Lambayeque** on the northern coast of Peru, reached its height in the early 11th century. But a prolonged drought, followed by catastrophic flooding, led to **cultural and political collapse**. In the early 12th century, the state recovered from the convulsions of the 11th century and rebuilt around a new capital at **Túcume**. New temples were built and the capital flourished until its conquest by the **Chimú** (see 1375), by which time there were 26 mounds and accompanying enclosures.

In central southern Africa, in what is now Zimbabwe, the **Mwene Mutapa Empire**, also known as **Great Zimbabwe** after its monumental capital, emerged as the most significant regional power. A kingdom of the **Shona** peoples that emerged around 900, Mwene Mutapa was initially based on cattle herding, but from around 1100 it took control of the lucrative **trade routes** linking the gold, iron, and ivory production centers of the interior to the **Arab trading kingdoms** on the east coast, which offered luxury goods from Asia.

Ceremonial knife

This gold knife is from the Middle Sicán culture in Peru. The early 1100s mark the threshold between the Middle and Late Sicán cultures.



The 12th-century Cathedral of St. Nicholas at Novgorod, Russia.

THE 12TH CENTURY SAW AN EXPLOSION OF CATHEDRAL BUILDING

all over Europe, as population growth, increased wealth, and architectural **advances** combined with religious zeal, **civic pride**, and the personal ambition of potentates. The development of the **Romanesque and Gothic styles** was given expression in the great cathedrals, but each region developed its own, distinctive idiom. In **Novgorod**, for instance, the **Cathedral of St. Nicholas** (started in 1113) was given domed cupolas.

The **Investiture Controversy** between the papacy and the Western emperors rumbled on (see 1071–80). **Henry IV's** failure to reconcile with the papacy had helped bring about his downfall; concerned that the ongoing dispute was undermining royal authority, his own family had conspired against him, and he was imprisoned. His successor, **Henry V** (1086–1125), launched a powerful expedition to **Italy** to force an **imperial coronation**.

Under duress (he was a prisoner of Henry at the time), **Pope Paschal II** offered major concessions on the investiture issue in the **Treaty of Sutri**, but he repudiated them the following year and the issue remained unsettled (see 1122).

c. 1100 Omar Khayyam composes the *Rubaiyat*

1101 Raymond IV of Toulouse invades Sultanate of Rum but is defeated by Danishmend Turks

c. 1102 Baldwin I, king of Jerusalem, defeats Fatimids at Jaffa

1105 Construction of the Ananda Temple in Burma

1107 Sultan of Rum battles Seljuks of Persia

1106 Henry V becomes Emperor of Rome

1107 Henry I of England makes peace with Anselm, Archbishop of Canterbury

1109 On death of Alfonso VI of Castile and León, Alfonso VII begins to style himself “Emperor of the Spains”

1110 Bogomils, a religious sect, persecuted in Constantinople

1111 Imperial coronation of Henry V in Rome

1115 Raymond Berengar III, count of Barcelona, expels Moors from Balearics

1112 Start of reign of Alaungsthur; Burmese kingdom of Pagan reaches height

1115 Matilda of Tuscany dies (b. 1046); Florence becomes a self-governing commune